

Referee report on “Boots in the Beat: Effects of Beat Policing on Victimization and Crime Perception”

I appreciate the authors’ substantial revision. In particular, the institutional setting is now much better explained, and I find the causal evidence on the overall effects of Plan Cuadrante convincing.

My remaining comments are narrower, but important for the interpretation of the results.

1. What does Plan Cuadrante identify?

The paper states in various places that permanent geographic assignment and greater local knowledge are the key mechanisms underlying the RF effects of the policy. I think this interpretation is stronger than what the evidence can establish.

Plan Cuadrante appears to have changed several features of frontline policing simultaneously. Assigning officers to smaller quadrants changes not only the officer-area relationships, but also the spatial organization of police presence. Depending on quadrant size, number of officers, and deployment practices, the reform may have effectively changed police density and patrol intensity, as well as response times. Each of these margins could plausibly affect crime, victimization, perceptions of safety, and citizen cooperation. Greater local knowledge is one compelling mechanism within this bundle, but it is not separately observed from these other operational changes.

I therefore think the paper should explicitly acknowledge that the results identify the effect of a broader organizational and deployment reform rather than the effect of local knowledge alone. A more defensible interpretation would be that Plan Cuadrante, combining permanent officer-to-quadrant allocation with an increase in police density, improved public safety and citizens’ perceptions of the police. Even holding the total number of officers fixed, reorganizing officers across smaller territorial units may change the intensity and concentration of local police presence.

One potentially useful exercise would be to characterize police density across quadrants, for example in terms of officers per square kilometer (or per capita). The illustrative map in the paper suggests that quadrants vary substantially in geographic size (and the smaller quadrants are the ones with higher baseline crime rates). If the authors observe the number of officers assigned to each quadrant, it would therefore be useful to document the distribution of officers per quadrant, and examine whether treatment effects vary with this measure of effective local police density. Police density may itself be correlated with response times, patrol intensity, and other operational margins, so it would still not isolate a single mechanism. But it would help characterize an important dimension of what the reform changed.

2. Resource changes

Figure 4 is most informative in the comparison between the bottom 40 percent of treated municipalities and control municipalities, which experienced similar resource growth. The interpretation should nevertheless be cautious. In particular, not even the bottom group or the control group experience zero resource growth. The exercise therefore does not isolate the effects of the geographic reorganization, *absent* those of changes in resources. Rather, it shows that the estimated gains are not confined to municipalities experiencing the largest resource expansions.

Relatedly, I think Table B3 is helpful. I would not dismiss these specifications simply because resource changes are themselves induced by treatment. Conditioning on policy-induced resource changes can still

be informative about whether the reduced-form effect is concentrated in places experiencing large resource expansions.

- Minor point: in Panel D in Table B3, the sample size falls substantially when the officer control is added. Why?

3. Contribution and framing

I would simplify the framing of the paper's contribution. The findings provide evidence that the organization and territorial deployment of police resources matter for public safety (and for citizens' perceptions, which by itself is a quite novel result), even though the specific mechanisms generating these gains cannot be fully decomposed. I think this is an interesting and important contribution on its own, and it does not require attributing the effects specifically to local knowledge.

By contrast, I do not find the analogy in the introduction to the spatial organization of health and education services particularly convincing. The underlying economic problem is different. Health and education services are typically supplied at fixed locations, with citizens incurring costs to access them, and supply being constrained. Here the relevant margin is about how a *mobile* public service is deployed across space. I understand the broad conceptual similarity the authors have in mind, but I do not think the analogy is sufficiently close to motivate a distinct contribution to the public/org. econ. literature along this dimension. I would therefore suggest dropping or substantially de-emphasizing this part of the introduction.